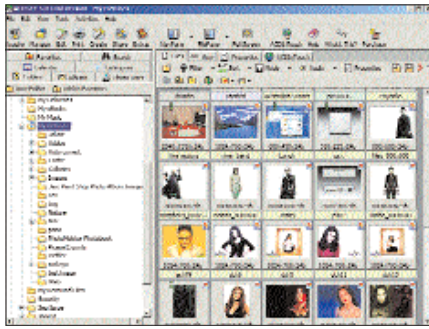




The cluttered interface lets ACD See down

A calendar view lets you view images by the year, month or date they were created. Although this is an improvement, it's nothing compared to the timeline feature provided by other software. ACD See has a comprehensive search feature, allowing you to search by varied criteria such as colour depth. But this gift has become a curse; there is not a single field where the user can enter keywords.

The slideshow is another area where ACD See shows signs of aging. Creating a custom slideshow using images from multiple directories is difficult. An important area that ACD See has completely left out, is that there is no tool for creating calendars, albums, or e-cards.

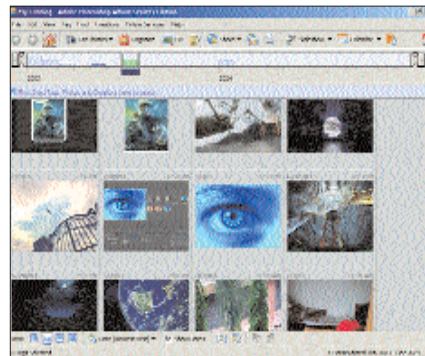
On the brighter side, the software provides a decent image editor—apart from basic image editing features, it allows you to use various easy-to-use filters such as pencil drawing and oil paint.

Moreover, the software can be used as the default viewer for all image files. However, in the end, the software doesn't serve its basic purpose, and is a product you can do without.

Adobe Photoshop Album 1.0

Adobe has entered this segment with Photoshop Album. It has all the traits of an Adobe product, from the friendly interface to the long boot up time that lets you memorise the names of the programmers that appear on the splash screen. Nevertheless, Photoshop Album is a comprehensive image management software.

User-friendliness is a characteristic that can be seen everywhere in the software. There are a few features that help this software beat the crowd—the time-



Photoshop Album has a very useful Timeline feature

How We Tested

We tested the software on a Pentium III 500 MHz system with 128 MB RAM, running Windows XP. A total of 200 images consisting of a mixture of existing images and photos taken using a Kodak CX6330 were used. The software were rated on the following features:

Interface: Being targeted at the home segment, the interface should be user-friendly. It should not be cluttered with buttons and menus, and all the important features should be easily accessible.

Ease of browsing: This is the most important aspect of the software. One should be able to view all the images based on parameters such as date, captions, etc. The software should have good searching abilities, based on more than one search criteria. You should be able to view the images by creating custom slideshows.

Image Editing: Apart for basic features such as cropping, size reduction, rotation and resizing, the software should be able correct some common errors in the images, such as red eye effect, glare, etc. The ability to add some effects to the image is a bonus.

Printing support: The layout of the print should be controllable, such as the number of images on a side. The program should also offer features such as index print. The software should provide features to use the images in the form of greeting cards, calendars, and albums. It should support archiving of images.

Extra features: Most software have unique features such as creating Panoramic images, PDA support, etc. These features may be appealing to certain people.

A Little Extra

A standard called EXIF (Exchangeable Image File Format), developed by the JEIDA (Japan Electronic Industry Development Association), is used in all cameras. Digital cameras use the EXIF format to store information related to the image taken, such as the date and time the photo was taken, model of the camera, the X resolution, Y resolution, exposure time, aperture value, etc.

Most image management software make use of the EXIF standard. Though novice users may not find much use in this, professional photographers can use this information to search for an image based on a specific parameter.

line shows the dates at which images were taken, and small bars indicate how many images were clicked in that month or on that date.

The second feature that makes Photoshop Album stand tall is its various ways of using images. One can create greeting cards, calendars and photo books, and even embed audio. The Creation Wizard makes the whole process a breeze, but all these creations can only be saved only as PDF files.

Another unique feature lets you search for an image that is visually similar to another. Select the images to be used for reference, and select **Find > By color similarity with selected photo(s)** to get all the similar images on your hard drive. You can also create 3D virtual rooms with your images on the walls, and take a 3D tour of a room.

Photoshop Album does have its share of woes. You cannot select multiple images by clicking and dragging the mouse over them, as in Windows Explorer. Also, the program only offers basic image editing features, and you cannot add any special effects to the images. In spite of these limitations, Photoshop Album's user-friendliness and features make it an attractive buy for home users.

Picasa 1.0

In direct contrast to ACD See, Picasa has an excellent interface. It is simple, with few but relevant buttons. The scroll bar position indicator always stays in the middle, and only needs to be dragged slightly to scroll. Another scroll bar at the bottom of the screen lets you adjust the number of thumbnails you see on the screen.